

Reviews

Taube, Moshe. *The Logika of the Judaizers: A Fifteenth-Century Ruthenian Translation from Hebrew*. The Israel Academy of Sciences and Humanities, Jerusalem, 2016. 720 pp. Illustration. Tables. Notes. Bibliography. Glossaries. Index. \$115.00.

THE critical edition of the *Book Called Logic* prepared by Moshe Taube is a long-anticipated publication in this field of the literature of Judaizers. As the author writes in his Preface, the aim of this book was to provide the necessary ground for a discussion of two medieval Arabic philosophical texts that were translated from their medieval Hebrew translations into the language of the Grand Duchy of Lithuania in the last quarter of the fifteenth century: (pseudo-?) Maimonides' *Logical Terminology* and Al-Ghazālī's *Intentions of the Philosophers*. Parts of these Ruthenian translations, which are called following Alexej Sobolevskij's appellation, 'the literature of the Judaizers', were combined in the Muscovite Principality into a single text, entitled *Logika*, first mentioned by Archbishop Gennadij of Novgorod in his 1489 letter to Iosaf, former archbishop of Rostov.

The book under review is structured in several parts, namely, the Preface followed by extensive references, the Introduction, the *Logika* of the Judaizers, consisting of Slavic texts, Hebrew texts, English translations and commentaries. The edition of the *Logika* is capped with a glossary of English terms, a glossary of Hebrew terms and a Slavic concordantial index. This book also contains a Hebrew preface. Right at the outset of this review, I deem it necessary to point out that Taube's critical edition of the *Logika* is a masterfully crafted book which has nevertheless some flaws as I will explain below.

The Introduction features a most exhaustive survey of the corpus of translations from Hebrew into Ruthenian. The first group contains Hebrew works integrated at the beginning of the fifteenth century into Russian compilations. The second group includes works belonging to the second half of the fifteenth century, in particular the first two sections of Abū Hāmid Muhammad Al-Ghazālī's *Intentions of the Philosophers* (Logic and Theology) and (pseudo-?) Maimonides' *Logical of the Sphere*. According to Taube, the text of the *Logika* was translated by a learned Jew from the Ruthenian lands who dictated his literal rendering into a vernacular, heavily Polonized Ruthenian (pp. 50–51). The Slavic collaborator put it down in writing, occasionally correcting in accordance with the bookish, heavily Polonized 'chancery language' (pp. 50–51). Whence, perhaps, a very peculiar language whose analysis in the book takes only six pages, which is not enough for a critical edition of this calibre. According to the author, several of the phonological and morphological features reflected in the orthography of the text clearly

indicate the scribe's "Belorussian" [! – A.D.] provenance (p. 51). With this in mind, the author confuses the $t' > c'$ affrication in Belarusian with the results of phonetic assimilations in *podvoicbse* 'repeats itself' (p. 51), describes 'v/u fluctuation' (better to name, alternation) as found in the following changes $v, vb > ou$, $ou > v$, $ou > vo$, $ou > vb$ (p. 52), although only the first change is historically grounded; he also mentions the x/h confusion (p. 53), which reflects in fact an assimilation process rather than a shift as attested primarily in Transcarpathia under a Hungarian influence. The author also believes that cases of relative clauses without a relative pronoun but with an anaphoric pronoun represent a syntactic calque of the Arabic asyndetic relative clause (p. 54), though this pattern reflects one of the types of relative clause chaining in East Slavic. Clearly, the aforementioned features are misleading enough to posit the Belarusian provenance of the translations collated as an 'eclectic edition' and presented as a 'reconstruction' by the author (p. 130). Needless to say, the question of delimitation of Ukrainian and Belarusian texts is of utmost importance for a critical edition of the Ruthenian texts.

Speaking about a possible Jewish motivation in the translation of the texts under consideration, Taube repeated his view first advanced in 2005 that learned Jews, such as Scharia, versed in scholarly and scientific literature, translated a variety of works of rationalist tenor for Slavs eager to gain access to such scholarly treasures; the Jews' true agenda was, according to the author, to attract their Slavic readers to Judaism (p. 69).

The section dealing with the history of research is particularly informative. It bridges the first works authored by Aleksej Sobolevskij and Vladimir Peretc via many other scholars to William F. Ryan. The section is a true trove of information about the respective texts and their research, though it looks somewhat unbalanced in how Taube treats some of his predecessors' contributions. Thus, he devotes excessive space to the discussion of Thomas M. Seeböhm's review essay of 1965 and monograph of 1977 (pp. 114–24). The author is prone to see 'clear anti-Semitic overtones' in the assessment of the Judaizers' language in Gustav Špet's monograph of 1922, according to whom, the *Logika* was translated into a fantastically corrupt Slavic-Russian language (pp. 93–94). Remarkably, the author remains oblivious of any Ukrainian contribution to the field, namely, in this context, Myxajlo Hruševs'kyj, who discussed the Ruthenian translations from Hebrew in his *History of Ukrainian Literature*, and Valerija Ničyk, who addressed the input of the Judaizers in the intellectual history of Ukrainians and Belarusians.

The edition of the Slavic texts of the *Logika*, accompanied by a full English translation, is based on an analysis of the nine extant Muscovite manuscripts (pp. 142–573). The author chose the readings that seemed closest to the Hebrew, and where two variants showed roughly the same level of proximity, Taube

preferred the Ruthenian variant to the Russian and the vernacular to the bookish (p. 131). Instrumental as it may look, this type of reconstruction does not allow us to say something definitive about the provenance of the respective translations and their language. Some comments, especially in reference to the Arabic original, are not convincing either, for instance, the explanation of the use of the preposition *o* in *molitva w nawsobnėišo(m)* ‘a sermon to the Most Distinguished’ by the alleged influence of the underlying Arabic ‘*alā* ‘on, about’ (p. 430).

The Slavic concordantial index (pp. 597–720) reflects shortcomings in the author’s interpretation of the Slavic language of the *Logika*. The orthographic variants are usually not alphabetized with a word’s main entry and are given separate entries. To give the most obvious examples, one should cite the *vъ > u* alternation as illustrated in *vzėti* and *ouzėti* ‘to take’ taken as separate entries, also *vkazati* next to *oukazati* ‘to guide’ (p. 605). Separate entries, according to the author, are *vpasti* and *vъpasti* ‘to fall’ (p. 607), though *vinnyj* is found in one entry next to such variants as *vyn’no*, *vin<n>o* and *vinъno* (n.sg.) ‘necessary, requiring’ (p. 605). The author does not provide any glossary of Slavic terms although the latter would benefit Taube’s research of the Ruthenian texts replete with numerous lexical and morphological innovations (p. 56). One comes across some obsolete spellings like *Belorussian* (p. 51) instead of *Belarusian*, *Kiev* (p. 9) rather than *Kyiv*. Despite these shortcomings, Taube’s critical edition is a ground-breaking contribution to the study of the literature of the Judaizers.

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Gimpelevich, Zina J. *The Portrayal of Jews in Modern Bielarusian Literature*. McGill-Queen’s University Press, Montreal and Kingston, London and Chicago, IL, 2018. xx + 479 pp. Illustrations. Notes. Bibliography. Index. \$95.00: £76.00.

BELARUS has been home to Jews for many centuries, and Professor Gimpelevich has provided a wide-ranging and comprehensive review of the relatively harmonious relationship of this substantial minority with their Christian neighbours, in sharp contrast to the situation in other Slav countries. Her ambitious monograph consists of eleven parts and two appendices. The first part is a thoroughly researched review of Jewish-Christian relations from the period of the Grand Duchy of Lithuania to the present, quoting extensively from existing scholarship, as well as from writers and poets. Using earlier published research and statistics, the author paints a broad yet thorough